

Καλλίας ὁ κωμικός

Callias the Comic Poet and the Symposium of Old Comedy

eul_aid: dkc

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic \(com, frg\)](#)
Domain: [Κωμωδία](#) [Comedy](#)
Format: [Ἑμμετρος](#) [Verse](#)

Callias was an Athenian comic poet active in the 5th century BCE during the period of Old Comedy. He is often identified as Callias, son of Hipponicus, a member of a famously wealthy and prominent Athenian family. The date of his career is firmly established by his competition against major playwrights like Aristophanes; ancient records indicate he defeated Aristophanes' first version of **The Clouds** at the City Dionysia in 423 BCE.

He is credited with a small number of comedies, of which only two titles survive with certainty from fragments and ancient references: **Pedetai** (The Prisoners) and **Grammatike Theoria** (The Scholarship Tour or The Alphabet Show). Both plays are lost and known only through fragments.

Callias is historically significant as a successful contemporary of Aristophanes, illustrating the vibrant competitive atmosphere of Athenian theater. His victory over the original **Clouds** is a notable event in the history of comedy. His play **Grammatike Theoria** is of particular interest to scholars. According to modern interpretations, its fragments suggest it was a satire of intellectual and sophistic trends, possibly featuring a contest between letters of the alphabet. This places his work within a subgenre of Old Comedy that engaged with contemporary linguistic and philosophical debates. As a probable aristocrat, his comedies provide a perspective from within the social elite that was often the target of comic ridicule.

Works (2)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Βίου Καθημερινοῦ](#) · [Fragments on Daily Life](#) · 19 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [Symposium and Satirical Fragments](#) · 37 passages